

SPRING 2026
ASA201
T/TR 1:20 – 2:40 PM
Chancellor Green 105

Introduction to Asian American Studies

Dr. Chris Chien

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Office hours: T12:00pm or by appointment | Morrison Hall 304A

Appointments: <https://calendly.com/chris-chien-princeton/30min>

OVERVIEW

This course is designed to introduce students to key debates in the fields of Asian American studies through its relationship to American Studies and Ethnic Studies. Rather than give a comprehensive or chronological survey of the fields, this course attempts to sample from the field in order to give students access to some important conversations, some relevant historical arcs and some pressing politically urgent questions. The texts have been chosen, therefore, for their contributions to an ongoing understanding of the global understanding of “Asian America” “Asia” and “Asian/American” within dynamic systems and processes of race, migration, subjectivity, property and knowledge

Our readings will provide us with the tools and theories to resist the seductions of developmental narratives of the citizen-subject and we will look for alternative accounts of history, subjectivity, politics and the social. Throughout we will situate “Asian America” as a regulating concept rather than as an idealization and we will consider the meaning of this concept within a global economy. Most weeks, we will select a central theme and then situate readings in a constellation around that theme. We will mostly focus on books or book chapters but you will always have the option of doing other suggested readings on the theme.

The themes/topics we will try to cover include: histories of capitalism; settler colonialism; imperialism; knowledge production/circulation; carceral power; migration; memory.

Questions we will address in this course include:

- What were the political economic, historical and social contexts that shaped the founding of “Asian America” as a formation?
- What is the relationship between “the global” and Asian America? How do events that take place in “Asia” impact Asian America and vice versa?

- How is “Asian America” relational to other racial and identity categories in the US?
- What are the different political possibilities of “Asian America”—as a regulating concept or a formation for liberation?

After completing this course, students will be able to:

- critically analyze how Asian Americans are represented in popular media, literature, public and official discourses
- understand and articulate the major debates and conversations in Asian American studies
- apply frameworks central to conversations around Asian American studies to texts not discussed in class
- explain the importance and limitations of interdisciplinary cultural studies to the broader field of Asian American Studies

Students will demonstrate their competency through class discussions, presentations, and written assignments.

This course is an American Studies elective.

REQUIRED TEXTS

Articles, online writing, and media will be available on Canvas/library database. There are no required texts, but you are, of course, encouraged to buy texts if they spark your interest.

Assignments

Canvas posts 20%
 Weekly presentations 15%
 Midterm essay 20%
 Final essay 25%
 Participation 20%

Canvas posts

Each week, by Monday and Wednesday at 9pm ET, you should post 250 words on the Canvas discussion board responding to my prompt or offering your own analyses/thoughts on the week’s readings and viewings. These will be used to jumpstart our conversations on Tuesdays and Thursdays. You do not have to post on the day you do a weekly presentation. This should total 23 posts over the course of 12 weeks.

Weekly presentations

Every class meeting (22 in total; starting on February 3) will begin with a short 5-minute presentation by one of your peers. Each presentation should focus on one

central idea from the assigned readings/viewings to discuss with the class. It should not just be a summary of the text, though that may be useful to start with, but a question, clarification, position, or connection to current events that you make in relation to the author's argument (for, against, mixed).

Signup (leave a comment with your name on the week you want to present on):

https://docs.google.com/document/d/1Dfoz_RShmHk2RCIZqO9jChmRe0st4_Y5ojo6OKEg-6I/edit?usp=sharing

COURSE REQUIREMENTS, POLICIES, AND EXPECTATIONS

1. You must complete all formal written assignments in order to pass the class.
2. It is your responsibility to get notes/catch up with classmates about what you have missed.
3. You are required to check your Princeton e-mail regularly.
4. In this class, we will be talking about topics that may be controversial and personal in nature. Since we will discuss dynamics of social and political inequality as well as histories of colonialism and imperialism, we may come across topics that are violent or upsetting in nature. I will do my best to inform you before these occur (eg. in our course readings) and you are always free to take a moment if you need to during class. As a member of this class, you will agree to be considerate and respectful and abide by Princeton's "[Rights, Rules, and Responsibilities](#)". If you feel that the Student Conduct Code has been violated, you should let the instructor or the Chair of the Efron Center know.

PARTICIPATION POLICY

I will be grading participation most heavily based on their own active and thoughtful participation. You do not have to be "*right*," but you do have to show your engagement with the texts and each other. This can come in the form of questions, asking for clarification about arguments or texts, building on what others in the class have said, and so on. I do not spend time in class stopping student disengagement from the discussion through, for example, online shopping/scrolling, but it will impact your participation grade.

UNIVERSITY CODE OF ACADEMIC CONDUCT

Academic Integrity and the Honor Code

Intellectual honesty is vital to an academic community and for my fair evaluation of your work. For these reasons, all students in this course are expected to abide by the Honor Code on examinations and to complete their written work in accordance with University regulations. On each written examination, test, or quiz administered in class, please write out and sign the following statement: "I pledge my honor that I

have not violated the Honor Code during this examination.” At the end of any written work completed outside of class for a grade, please type or write out and sign the following statement: "This paper represents my own work in accordance with University regulations." For electronic submissions, you may type your name preceded by the notation /s/, which stands for “signature.” Please be aware that I will refer any suspected infractions of the honor code or the University’s academic regulations to the [Honor Committee](#) or the [Faculty-Student Committee on Discipline](#). If you are found to have plagiarized or copied the work of another scholar or student on any portion of an assignment or exam, you will receive an automatic “0,” which may result in a failing grade for the course.

***AI USE POLICY:** We will go over in detail the use of LLM (large language model) generative AI and ChatGPT in class. In short, while many educators discourage its use entirely, my policy is that using it as a research tool is acceptable—using it to generate text that you pass off entirely, *or in part*, as your own **is not**. If you choose to use it, it should *only* be a research tool/aid, not a substitute for your own writing or thinking.

WRITING IS THINKING!

You are still accountable for the final piece of writing you turn in (it’s quality and accuracy) including its citations, formatting, and style. Remember that thoughtful engagement with the issues and concepts of the course are key.

UNIVERSITY ACCOMMODATIONS AND RESOURCES

Disability Services and Academic Accommodations

Students must register with the [Office of Disability Services](#) (ods@princeton.edu; 258-8840) for disability verification and determination of eligibility for reasonable academic accommodations. Requests for academic accommodations for this course should be made at the beginning of the semester or as soon as possible for newly approved students. I encourage students with approved accommodations to contact me at the beginning of the semester and again before major course assessments. Please note that no accommodations for a disability will be made without authorization from ODS or without advance notice.

Students with Disabilities or Learning Differences

Princeton welcomes students with disabilities and values their diverse experiences and perspectives. If you anticipate or experience a barrier to learning in the classroom or in completing assignments or exams, please know there is support for you. Students who wish to request classroom accommodations can do so through the [Office of Disability Services](#) (ODS). If you have been approved for accommodations through the ODS, please contact me via email as soon as possible so we can develop an implementation plan together.

Academic Resources

Princeton offers extensive academic support to undergraduates. I encourage you to take advantage of the following resources:

- [The Writing Center](#) - The Writing Center offers student writers free one-on-one conferences with experienced fellow writers trained to consult on assignments in any discipline.
- [The McGraw Center](#) - The McGraw Center for Teaching and Learning offers one-on-one learning consultations that can be particularly useful for developing active reading strategies, project management skills, and note-taking tactics. You can make an appointment for an individual consultation by visiting their website. The McGraw Center also supports group study hall and peer tutoring.
- [Princeton Undergraduate Research Calendar](#) - Princeton's Undergraduate Research Calendar (PURC) helps you navigate the many programming opportunities and resources available to support your research at Princeton. Use their one-stop website to learn about upcoming events and plan ahead for important funding, internship, and fellowship deadlines.
- [Princeton Correspondents on Undergraduate Research](#) - Drawn from across class years and divisions, the Correspondents promote a culture of research and scholarship amongst undergraduates, support students through all stages of research and independent work, demystify the research process, and empower more students to get involved in research opportunities that enable them to make well-informed decisions about their course of study and career. The PCUR blog helps demystify the steps of the research process, highlights different kinds of research opportunities, and offers insight into what it's like to do research and independent work in different disciplines.
- [Reference Librarians](#) - Reference librarians can help students make a research plan, find sources (electronic and print), and provide guidance through the research and citation process.

SPRING 2026 TENTATIVE READING SCHEDULE

Date	Topic and Reading
Week 1	INTRODUCTIONS AND FOUNDINGS
Tuesday, January 27	Saya Abney, "A project of love: Ethnic studies and the legacy of the Third World Liberation Front" https://www.dailycal.org/archives/a-project-of-love-ethnic-studies-and-the-legacy-of-the-third-world-liberation-front/article_42579d7f-a28b-5a83-9af9-8ce5ae2e6945.html
Thursday, January 29	I Wor Kuen, "Revolution, National Question, and Asian Americans," <i>IWK Journal</i> 1 (August 1974), https://www.marxists.org/history/erol/ncm-8/iwk-asian-nat-question.htm . JM Wong, "Pingshe: Retrieving an Asian American Anarchist Tradition," <i>Amerasia Journal</i> 34 (2008): 132-51 <u>Themes</u> : Histories/inheritances; protest cultures; Third World/nationalisms; anarchism; Asian American radicalisms
Week 2	WHAT IS "ASIAN AMERICA"?
Tuesday, February 3	Lisa Lowe, <i>Immigrant Acts</i> (Chapter 1, Heterogeneity, Hybridity, Multiplicity p. 60-84) Gary Okihiro, "Is Yellow Black or White?"
Thursday, February 5	<u>Themes</u> : Immigration; non-homogenous experiences of Asian America; racial exclusion as fundamental to capitalism; difference, assimilation, coalition
Week 3	
Tuesday, February 10	Viet Thanh Nguyen, <i>Race and Resistance</i> (Introduction, p.3-31) Kandice Chuh, <i>Imagine Otherwise</i> (Introduction, p.1-29)
Thursday, February 12	[EXTRA CREDIT]: Attend Ocean Vuong lecture: https://effroncenter.princeton.edu/events/2026/ocean-vuong-emperor-gladness [EXTRA CREDIT]: Attend KIM'S CONVENIENCE sometime this week: https://www.mccarter.org/kimsconvenience <u>Themes</u> : Identity politics; essentialism; subjectivity; ethical subjects

Week 4 Tuesday, February 17 Thursday, February 19	ASIAN/AMERICA AND EMPIRE Espiritu, Lowe, Yoneyama, "Transpacific Entanglements," <i>Flashpoints for Asian American Studies</i> [Canvas] Simeon Man, <i>Soldiering Through Empire</i> (Chapter 3, Race War in Paradise: Hawai'i's Vietnam War, p.77-103) Aloha, Vietnam: Race and Empire in Hawai'i's Vietnam War <u>Themes</u>: Decolonizing praxis; afterlives of US militarism; knowledge production; imperial gendering/racialization
Week 5 Tuesday, February 24 Thursday, February 26	Jasbir K. Puar, <i>Terrorist Assemblages: Homonationalism in Queer Times</i>(Chapter 1, The Sexuality of Terrorism, p. 37-79) [Part of Participation]: February 23: Attend Nadine Attewell lecture: https://effroncenter.princeton.edu/events/2026/asian-american-studies-lecture-nadine-attewell <u>Themes</u>: State incorporation of queerness; homonationalism; imperialism; "Global War on Terror"
	IN-CLASS MIDTERM – February 26
Week 6 Tuesday, March 3 Thursday, March 5	THE REFUGEE CONDITION AND FORCED MIGRATIONS Yen Le Espiritu, <i>Body Counts</i> (Chapter 1, Critical Refugee Studies) Eric Tang, <i>Unsettled: Cambodian Refugees in the NYC Hyperghetto</i>(Introduction, Refugee in the Hyperghetto, p. 1-28) <u>Themes</u>: Production of refugee identities; militarism; memory; refugee resistance and agency
Week 7 Tuesday, March 10 Thursday, March 12	SPRING BREAK
Week 8 Tuesday, March 17 Thursday, March 19	Shweta Jayawardhan, "Vulnerability and Climate Change Induced Human Displacement" Mimi Thi Nguyen, <i>The Gift of Freedom</i> (Introduction, The Empire of Freedom, p.1-33)

	<u>Themes:</u> Liberalism; narratives of redemption/gratefulness; urban poverty/discrimination; carcerality
Week 9 Tuesday, March 24 Thursday, March 26	ASIAN RACIALIZATION AND TECH/FUTURITY Roh, Huang, and Niu. "Introduction," <i>Techno-Orientalism: Imagining Asia in Speculative Fiction, History, and Media.</i>" Huan He. "Isamu Noguchi's Gardens: Yellow Peril in the Age of Information." <i>Configurations</i>, vol. 32 no. 1, 2024, p. 25-50. [CLASS VISIT FROM PROF. HE] <u>Themes:</u> Cybernetics, Informatics, Asian racialization, techno-futurism, liberalism, "techno-orientalism"
Week 10 Tuesday, March 31 Thursday, April 2	MODEL MINORITIES? Vivian Yan Gonzalez, "Model minority or myth? Reexamining the politics of SI Hayakawa" Nishant Upadhyay, <i>Indians on Indian Land</i>: Chapter 1: Unsettling Brahmanism ***Recommended: Paul Nadal, "How Neoliberalism Remade the Model Minority Myth" <u>Themes:</u> Racialization, multiculturalism, racial liberalism, neoliberalism
Week 11 Tuesday, April 7 Thursday, April 9	GENDER, SEX, BODY, NATION Iyko, <i>Alien Capital: Asian Racialization and the Logic of Settler Colonial Capitalism</i>. Chapter 2: "Unnatural Landscapes: Romantic Anticapitalism and Alien Degeneracy" (p. 73-114) David L. Eng, Jack Halberstam, and Jose Esteban Muñoz, "What's Queer about Queer Studies Now?" <i>Social Text</i> (p. 1-17) <u>Themes:</u> Gendered nationhood; 'Asian American Woman' as category; reproduction (social identities and capital); Asian queerness as disrupting normative time/labor

Week 12 Tuesday, April 14 Thursday, April 16	LABOR/MIGRATION Nayan Shah, <i>Stranger Intimacy</i> (Chapter 2: Policing Strangers and Borderlands, p.53-89). Manu Karuka, <i>Empire's Tracks</i>, "Chapter 3: Railroad Colonialism." <i>Who Killed Vincent Chin?</i> (87 mins, dirs. Christine Choy, Renee Tajima-Peña) [available in course reserves] <u>Themes</u>: Sexual and labor discipline; settler colonialism and imperialism; anti-Asian violence; Yellow Peril; transnational capital
Week 13 Tuesday, April 21 Thursday, April 23	AA/PI? PACIFIC ISLANDER AND INDIGENOUS CULTURES Haunani Kay Trask, <i>Asian Settler Colonialism</i>, Candace Fujikane and Jonathan Okamura eds. (Chapter 1, Settlers of Color and 'Immigrant' Hegemony, p. 45-66). View: Haunani Kay Trask Speech (Jan 17, 1993). Dean Itsuji Saranillio, "Why Asian settler colonialism matters: a Thought Piece on Critiques Debates and Indigenous Difference" [Canvas] <u>Themes</u>: Indigenous epistemologies/lifeways; militarism and colonialism; Resistance and political self-determination; native sovereignty; Asian settlerhood
	FINAL EXAM DUE ON CANVAS [SATURDAY, MAY 9 @12pm]